



FROM ANY FIELD

FOR
EVERY
PROBLEM.

STRATEGY 2026-2027

WHO WE ARE

Every year, thousands of University of Toronto students come up with promising innovative ideas. Few translate into entrepreneurial action, as few know where to start.

Innovation OnBoard works to change that, creating the shortest path from inspiration to innovation.



Founded at UBC in 2017 and brought to UofT in 2024, we are a pan-Canadian, student-led NGO & UofT-recognized student group with a simple approach: we put students and early-career researchers in the room with founders, investors, and industry leaders, get them to talk, work through ideas, and map out a path to innovation together.

We make entrepreneurship tangible for every student daring to try. We call on people who have succeeded to come and share their path. We collaborate to create value for each other, giving ecosystem players a hand in shaping the generation they'll one day work alongside.

Our goal is to ensure that talent has the skills to innovate, the network to excel, and reasons to do it at UofT and in Canada.

ADDRESSING THE GAP BETWEEN STUDENT INTEREST AND ENTREPRENEURIAL ACTION

Innovation is critical to translating research, expertise and new ideas into practical solutions that address real-world needs, generate value and drive long-term growth. This process only begins when individuals are motivated to explore entrepreneurship and empowered to act on their ideas. Students are central to this pipeline as the next generation of researchers, founders and innovation leaders.

At UofT, students show tremendous interest, but the knowledge gap remains:

9 IN 10

want to learn more
about
entrepreneurship

5 IN 10

have considered
launching or joining
a startup

9 IN 10

feel they lack the
entrepreneurial
knowledge to start

Existing accelerators serve teams with developed ideas.

IOB provides an earlier, accessible starting point: exposure, foundational skills, interdisciplinary connections and a clear next step.

CONNECTING STUDENTS TO A GROWING INNOVATION ECOSYSTEM

Canada and the University of Toronto are expanding the infrastructure available to support venture creation. More than 1,500 venture-backed startups have emerged from the U of T community, raising over \$14 billion in the past five years. Major investments such as the Schwartz Reisman Innovation Campus, the Eva and Allen Lau Commercialization Catalyst Prize and the more than \$30 million Genesys University Seed Fund are creating new pathways from research and invention to investment-ready ventures.

This infrastructure has the greatest impact when students have the knowledge, confidence and relationships to use it. As the place where emerging talent develops, universities are uniquely positioned to connect students with these opportunities and help them navigate the path from ideas to meaningful economic and societal impact.

Innovation OnBoard connects students with founders, investors, and industry to **spark curiosity, **build** knowledge, and **accelerate** the leap from inspiration to **innovation**.**

STRENGTHENING CANADA'S INNOVATION FOUNDATIONS

TALENT

- 46% • Canadian tech wages vs US counterparts
TMU Dais Institute, 2023
- 81% • Employers prioritized skills over credentials
World Economic Forum, 2025
- 80% • Entry-level hiring down per Q at AI-adopting firms since 2023
Hosseini & Lichtinger, Harvard, 2026

Canada and UofT produce world-class talent, but much of its potential remains untapped. Mobilizing this talent requires greater entrepreneurial exposure, industry networks, and practical pathways from knowledge to innovation.

R&D

- 6th • Ranked globally on research impact by citations
CCA, 2025
- 20th • Ranked globally on innovation output
WIPO, 2025
- >70% • Canadian life sci exits returns flow to international firms
CCA, 2025

Canada and UofT produce globally significant research, with particular strength in artificial intelligence, quantum technologies, biotechnology, and health innovation. The challenge is not discovery, but the consistency with which it is translated into domestic economic value.

IOB EQUIP



IOB equip students and researchers with foundational knowledge and confidence in entrepreneurship, commercialization and venture building.

IOB TRANSLATE



Provides students with direct exposure to commercialization pathways, industry needs, venture-building principles, and institutional support, embedding translational thinking into their development as researchers and founders.

STRENGTHENING CANADA'S INNOVATION FOUNDATIONS

CAPITAL

- 60% • Of total funding is from US investors, highest since 2017 CPE Analytics, 2026
- 40% • Canadian seed rounds smaller than US Startup Genome / NACO, 2026
- 47% • Decrease in seed-stage funding YoY in 2024. -28% in deal count in H1 2025 CVCA, 2024; 2025

Canadian and U of T founders face a fragmented path to early-stage capital, requiring them to navigate investment rounds, public funding and R&D tax incentives. This complexity can discourage early initiation or slow momentum.

IOB CONNECT



Build capital readiness by putting emerging founders in the same room as investors, mentors, and incubators

RISK

- 4th • Ranked globally in early-stage entrepreneurial activity GEM, 2024/2025
- ~0% • Growth in number of new businesses 2015-2024 OECD, 2026
- 32.4% • Of Canadian-led high-potential startups in 2024 stayed in Canada Leaders Fund, 2025

Students show strong entrepreneurial ambition, but financial and career risks, limited early support and poor capital readiness prevent many ideas from becoming sustainable ventures.

IOB EMPOWER



Make informed risk-taking understandable and achievable, so ideas get explored instead of shelved

INNOVATION ONBOARD TWO YEARS IN

Throughout the academic year, IOB runs workshops and networking events on topics including venture building, fundraising, commercialization, deep technology, life sciences innovation, and entrepreneurship in research. This programming culminates in an annual pitch competition, where student founders pitch their ideas, receive feedback from industry experts, and connect with mentorship, funding, and commercialization pathways.

2000+

ATTENDEES
ENGAGED

15+

EVENTS
DELIVERED

40+

MENTORS
AND JUDGES

66

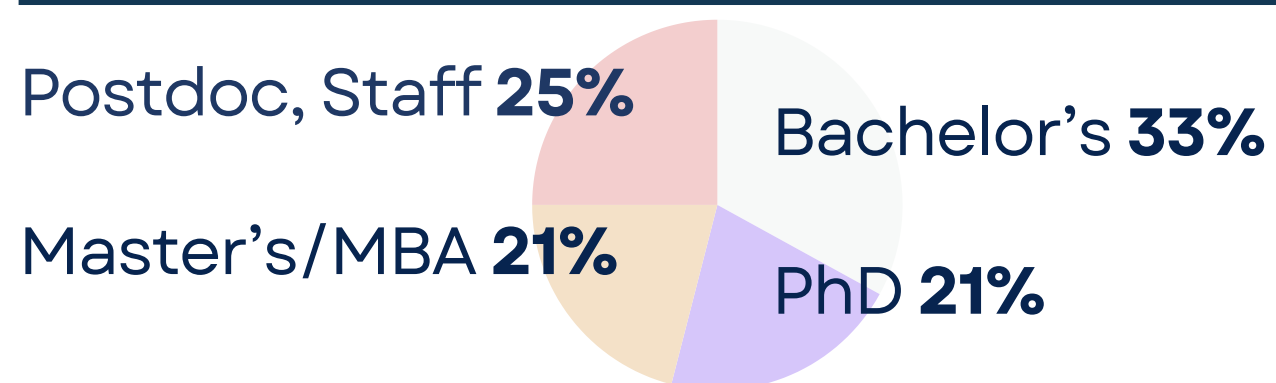
TEAMS IN 2 PITCH
COMPETITIONS

>>>

21

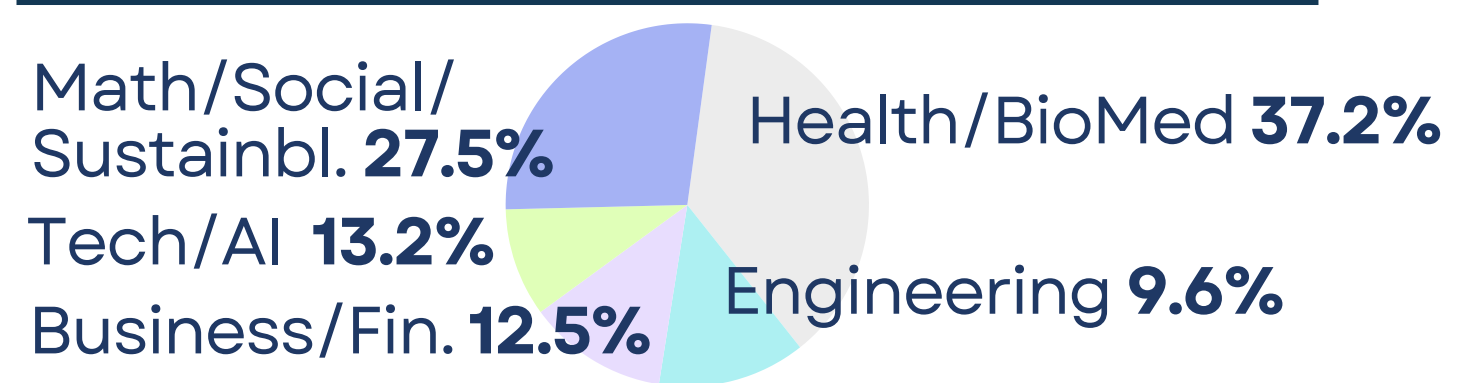
TEAMS TO UOFT
INCUBATORS

ACADEMIC OUTREACH



IOB engages participants across all stages of academic study and professional development

DISCIPLINARY BREADTH



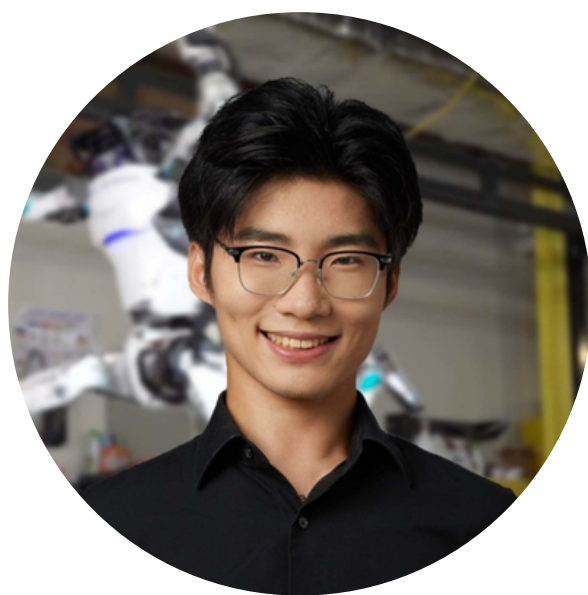
IOB is building an interdisciplinary community by design.

PARTNERSHIPS



IOB community spans across the most research intensive faculties at UofT. To provide participants with a clear pathway into commercialization, we have partnered with leading UofT entrepreneurship centres and incubators.

INNOVATION ONBOARD SUCCESS STORIES



Kino Song

FROM STUDENT FOUNDER TO SCALING
HEALTHCARE VENTURE

Kino Song engaged with IOB as a first-year Master's student, becoming a finalist in the IOB Pitch Competition while building TalkToMedi. He went on to place second in U of T's 2025 Desjardins Startup Prize. Today, TalkToMedi's EMR-integrated AI platform serves a Canadian clinic network representing over 1.5 million patients. The company recently closed a pre-seed round led by Comma Capital, marking its progression from student venture to scaling healthtech company.



Dr. Sushant Singh

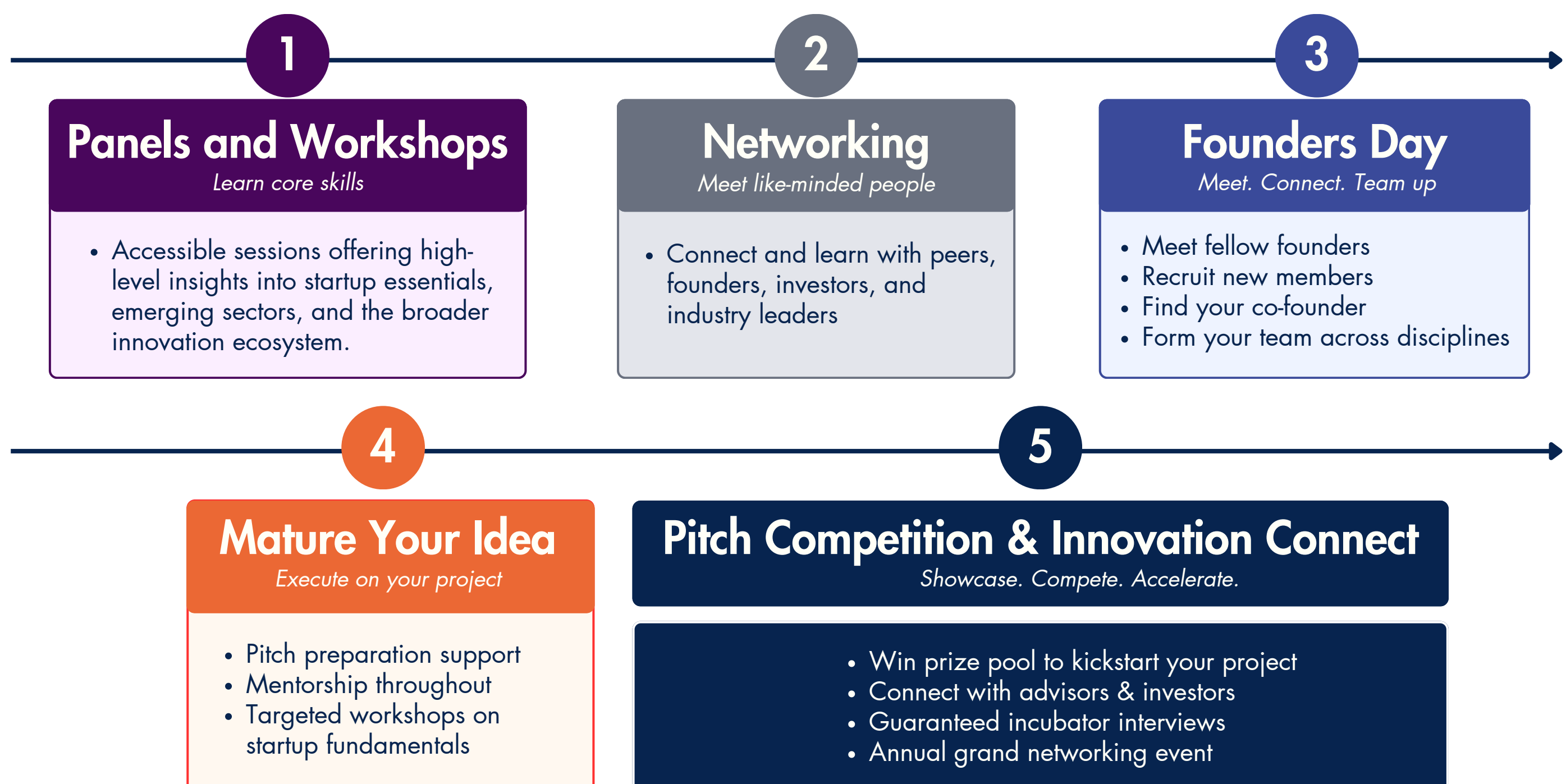
ADVANCING RESEARCH FROM THE
LAB TOWARD COMMERCIALIZATION

Dr. Sushant Singh joined IOB as a PhD researcher and became an IOB Pitch Competition finalist with VRiT, a regenerative medicine startup translating bioprinting and skin regeneration research toward clinical application. VRiT placed third in the 2025 Desjardins Startup Prize, then returned in 2026 to win the \$40,000 top prize. Now a postdoctoral fellow and CEO/Co-Founder of VRiT, Sushant continues advancing the company's handheld bioprinting technology for wound and skin repair.

STRATEGY 2026-2027

In two years, IOB UofT has demonstrated the demand and potential of a student-driven innovation ecosystem, supporting talent in advancing ideas, accessing mentorship, and translating expertise into emerging ventures. With a strong foundation of partnerships and ecosystem connections, the next opportunity is to scale this model into a platform that strengthens Canada's innovation pipeline from the earliest stages of talent development.

STUDENT JOURNEY



PRIORITY INNOVATION DOMAINS

Programming covering wide range of topics, with particular emphasis on AI, life sciences, cleantech, and fintech.

EXPANDING THE NETWORK

Diverse pool of founders, operators, academics, and commercialization experts to evaluate and guide emerging ventures.

ATTRACTING EARLY CAPITAL

Increasing prize pool and strengthening pathways into incubators and accelerators for fresh ideas at the earliest stage.

OUR TEAM

EXECUTIVE



Bei Qi Yan
PhD, Medical Biophysics
President



Sachin Kodate
MBA, Rotman
VP, External Relations



Artem Kushnirenko
PhD, Medical Biophysics
VP, Partnership & Outreach



Alejandra Featherston-Rajcic
Masters of Health Informatics
VP, Events & Programming



Karida Liu
PhD, Pharmacology
VP, Marketing



Cadence Kwok
BSc, Psychology
Dir., Events & Programming



Hafsa Ovais
BComm, Rotman
Dir., Partnership & Outreach

ADVISORY



Victoria Liu
PhD, Psychology
IOB Co-Founder



Ziming Cheng
PhD, Psychology
IOB Co-Founder



Sophie Stuart-Sheppard
H2i
Programming Lead



Mark Smithyes
Janus Life Science Consulting
Founder & Managing Director



Kate Grant
Fasken
Business Advisor



Salim Kandedi
Corvita Biomedical Inc
CEO, IOB Pitch Winner

EVENTS HIGHLIGHTS

